

Shadows of Titan

“You lost in thought again?” Darius asked in a murmur, slowing slightly to turn and look down at her.

Myth’s throat went dry, the drink buzzing in her head making her slow to formulate a sensible answer. “I hadn’t expected such a nice get-together.”

He didn’t speak, and Myth kept her gaze forward. “Plus, who would have thought the people who could crack the planet in half are worried about soup temperatures?”

He gave a soft laugh, turning and coming to a gentle stop. “Yeah,” he said. “I forget sometimes that not everyone grew up with this.”

She looked at him finally. “Did you?”

“Mostly,” he said, brushing a strand of hair out of her face. “The Apex schools, elite combat forces with formal table etiquette by thirteen. I knew a salad fork before I knew a friend.”

Myth nodded, resisting the urge to chew on her lip. He brought her hand to his lips and kissed her knuckles lightly, leaving a blazing trail of fire and nerves in his wake. He pulled her into his chest, his lips brushing her ear, sending shivers down her spine. “Let’s go home.”

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The room was quiet save for the sound of the energy suppressors, but Thal's internal clock told him it was at least close to oh-four-hundred hours. There was minimal light coming from the embedded floor strips and the room still held the warmth of energy.

He blinked hard, his head aching from the alcohol, but his body felt refreshed. Rhea shifted behind him, her soft fingers grazing the side of his thigh in passing. The door slid shut silently behind her green frame, and he rolled over to watch Lynx, who was still asleep. His spine curved perfectly into the silk sheets, his arm dangling over his face carelessly. Thal moved gently, untangling his legs from Lynx and the sheets, and padded across the room to his desk, not bothering to get dressed yet. His wings sagged limply behind him, when they should have been bright and alert. He sighed, leaning back gingerly in his chair, watching Lynx move softly, his breathing shifting into a soft snore.

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He opened his terminal, the bright white and cold against his bare chest. He checked all the standard systems without a hitch before going deeper into the AAN processors, looking. Something was wrong, and he didn't know what exactly. Myth's presence, yes, but something more than that bothered him. She had looked directly at him, the same way she used to, just for a split second.

He shook his head. The terminal blinked a silent red light; the system must have flagged something. He sifted through the data until he found the problem: a packet lodged in a black-blind cache, zero trace of where it came from or where it was intended to go.

He flipped it open, his fingers flying along the keyboard working on the encryption. It wasn't the average sequencing either, at least a Tier Eight. He was rewarded when the file barfed its contents:

SUBJECT: 001X // "MYTH" TERMINATION RECORD (CORRUPTED DOWNLOAD)

TRIAL 731-J: RESONANCE LOG (Thallion V. / Myth A.) (PARTIAL DOWNLOAD)

PROJECT CHIMERA

— PERSONNEL FILE: FANE S. DRYST 197F278 (TERMINATED)

He stared at the screen, the cursor blinking in steady intervals. A quiet pressure was building behind his sternum, a panic that made the air feel thin.

Behind him, there was a soft shift of silk and Lynx stopped snoring, sitting up and rubbing his eyes as he squinted into the dim light. "Thal?" His voice was thick with tiredness. "What time is it?"

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“Around oh-four,” he answered quietly, his wings twitching weakly as he tried to discreetly catch his breath.

Lynx rose from the bed, stretching languidly before he moved soundlessly across the floor, the air cooling subtly around him as his Nullify energy regulated slowly.

“Your wings,” Lynx said quietly, his face tight.

“I’m fine,” he said flatly.

“Liar.”

He exhaled through his teeth, and before he could move, Lynx had grabbed the terminal, turning it around, his eyes quickly surveying the information. Thal leaned back gingerly, refusing to look at Lynx’s face.

“What the hell is this?” Lynx asked finally.

He didn’t answer right away, instead looking at the highlighted text Lynx shoved under his nose.

“You’re on this file, Thal,” Lynx pressed. “Why are *you* on this file with Fane Dryst?”

“I don’t know. I haven’t read it yet,” he finally answered, his voice low. “I was running security checks. It was buried in a blind cache.”

Lynx leaned in closer, his usual cool demeanour replaced by a sharp intensity, his silver-grey eyes piercing into Thal’s soul before he turned back to the screens. His fingers tapped through the terminal, and Thal leaned in to see him click through the fragmented entries.

“For gods' sake, Thal...” Lynx’s voice came out barely above a whisper. He began to read aloud, his voice shaky. “Resonance Trial 731-J, Subject Thallion V. Wing integrity at thirty-eight percent capacity. Chronic degeneration... Subject Myth A? Bio-restorative output over ninety-two percent post...”

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Thal felt a sharp pang in his chest as a familiar ache shot through the joints of his wings, a pain he lived with every single day, feeling amplified under the stress.

Lynx's eyes flicked to Thal's and then back to the screen. "Forced synergy... forced synergy? **Thal!**"

He leaned back, squeezing his eyes shut as a memory fragment pierced through his mind like a shard of broken glass. A blinding, warm, and violet light, and Myth's dark face, strained and streaked with tears. He felt waves of guilt wash over him, and he bit back tears until his mouth tasted like iron.

"Forced synergy protocol, activated," Lynx continued, his voice shaky. "Subject Myth's output is... the data is corrupted... causing unprecedented stabilisation in Subject Thallion's wing matrix. Cellular regeneration recorded at four hundred... four hundred and fifty percent above baseline!"

He could feel Lynx's eyes on him again, and he squeezed his eyes shut and turned away. He didn't need to be scolded right now; he needed to figure out a plan. Lynx grabbed him roughly by the jaw, forcing him to face him, his face full of fury. "Thal... you... this girl? Your wings? You need to explain to me what is going on. **Now.**"

Thal pulled his jaw away roughly and clicked to the next file, shoving the screen in Lynx's face before standing and walking to the large bay window behind them.

"Termination record?" Lynx's face looked sick in the reflection of the window. "Incident 731 resulted in an uncontrolled resonance cascade. Containment Breach Sector 4... the data's corrupted. Fane Solomon Dryst reported on-site, causing catastrophic failure."

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A cold wave washed over Thal, and the panic he had felt earlier set in now with a cold, crushing weight. He knew Fane had been there; even if he couldn't trust his memories, he knew Fane was the cause of this.

"Subject Thallion V. experienced critical exposure, recommended for immediate Level Five memory alteration protocol..." Lynx's voice died away. "They wiped your memory?" His face was a mask of horror, his jaw slack.

"Read the rest," Thal commanded, his voice a low growl.

Lynx's gaze dropped back to the screen, his voice shaky. "Subject Myth A. deemed too unstable a variable, the data's corrupted here... recommendation: permanent termination."

The words hung in the air, the silence pressing in on his ears. *Permanent termination. Who gave this report? What happened to Dryst?* This left more questions than answers, but at least he knew for certain: he shouldn't trust his memories about anything. Even the pleasant ones.

His wings flared involuntarily, a sharp, grinding pain tearing through him. He staggered, his knee hitting the cold floor, his wings dropping against the tile. Lynx was at his side instantly, his Nullify energy surging through Thal's body, dampening the spike.

"Thal," Lynx started. But he stopped and shook his head. "Does synergising with Rhea still help?"

Thal gave a stiff nod, his jaw tight. Only a select few knew about his condition, and those few were chosen to help, not to be a burden. He needed to get Myth back; the others could only temporarily slow the degeneration. Even Rhea's healing energy couldn't undo even a little degeneration without almost dying. He straightened up, standing tall, the pain in his back adding to his anger. Fane had lied, no surprise. The AAN had lied, no surprise. But Myth was lying too,

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and he had to find out how deep her lies went. She certainly didn't remember much, or she would have gone berserk already—

“Who is Myth?” Lynx asked, breaking into his train of thought. “And don't lie to me. I know you don't remember everything, but it's clear you know who she was. So who was she?”

He didn't answer right away as he pressed the heel of his hand into his temple, forcing back the throb that was building behind his eyes. “She was someone who could heal me. We used to be... close,” he said finally, his voice tight.

Lynx stood still behind him, his Nullify-field still tight, pressing against his body defensively. “So what do we do?”

He turned from the window finally, narrowing his eyes. “We... we do nothing. It's just some old cache floating in the void.”

“But—”

Thal raised a hand. “This is old information. Myth is dead. Clearly. Besides emotional drudgery, there is nothing more to say.”

“Fane—”

“Fane has always been and always will be a problem unless we kill him. Get dressed; we have work to do,” he said resolutely.

Lynx clearly realised there was no room for argument and his Nullify energy subsided. He turned slowly and gathered his robes from the night before. Thal watched him in silence, his mind buzzing. Lynx gave him one last look before he walked out, the door hissing closed, finally leaving Thal in silence.

He knew exactly what he needed to do as he moved back to the console, his fingers moving swiftly over the terminal as he sat down. Within seconds, he'd pulled up Darius's

schedule: he was set to do another public viewing and on light-duty protocol. Standard Apex procedure. He tapped around quickly: at midday, a Chancellor's check-in, originally scheduled for the next week. Thal entered his credentials and closed the tab grimly. He then opened the secure communication line to Mereen and typed using sparse, coded words. She needed to hold Valkyrie there, with no optics, so that fiery bastard wouldn't know until it was too late. They all wouldn't know until it was too late, all except Varian. He pulled up the secure relay channel and typed rapidly:

1105–1115 HRS. GARDEN PROMENADE LOOP 3: DEPLOY 1 SWEETLING

Thal felt a chill down his spine as he pressed send; he remembered them clearly. Not fatal to Apexes, but definitely would do its job of causing mass panic. He closed the terminal, rolling his neck slowly. He stood, stretching his arms above his head, relishing the pain in his back when he heard his door hiss open again. Lynx was back, dressed in his normal black uniform, his grey eyes a sharp contrast to his slate-black hair. Thal admired his olive-brown skin, holding a hand in Lynx's direction. Lynx walked slowly across the room, his Nullify-field brushing gently against Thal's skin as he approached.

"You good?" Thal asked, capturing his chin in his hand gently.

"Yeah." Lynx exhaled slowly, looking at him searchingly before closing the distance between them. Thal pulled him over to the bed, tugging Lynx's clothes back off.

Until he found a way to permanently fix his wing degradation, synergy was the only thing holding them together. Synergising with Lynx was sharp, clean, precise, and perfect. His body responded to his energy immediately, and the weight of his wings lifted.

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After he found a permanent fix to his degradation problem, he would be with Lynx for good, not just to save himself.

Chapter 29

Fane watched his monsters breathing in the dark. The only light was coming from the holding chambers, just enough to show their terrible countenance. He felt a smile stretch over his face as he examined his creations. Row upon row of ever-mutating amalgams of bone, flesh, and steel, growing and filling their containment tanks.

Varian stood with his hands folded neatly, his red, beady eyes wide with admiration, his excitement radiating off him.

“They are beautiful tonight,” Varian whispered, stepping reverently closer to the tank.

“They are starving,” Fane growled, his voice filtering through the exo-suit in a metallic rasp. He stood, a colossus of pulsating, corrupted tech well over ten feet tall, but the horrors in front of him dwarfed him. Forty years of obsessive genius poured into each mammoth frame.

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Their forms, well over twenty-five feet even when hunched over, stood as a perfect mockery of life as they hung suspended in the nutrient-rich fluid. Their massive, elongated arms ended in claws of sharpened Inconel, their heads covered in massive helmets of tool-steel, maws lined with row upon row of titanium teeth. Their ribs pulsed with slow, powerful energy, constantly generating and growing, their bodies in a never-ending, agonising state of flux.

“They are starving for blood. Violence. **Fear**,” he snarled, turning from the tanks.

Varian’s red-lensed glasses were fogged with his heavy breathing as he took in the sight around him.

“They’re magnificent,” the scientist almost wept. “And perfect timing, too. We have received a directive... from Commander Voxx.”

Fane’s back stiffened, but he said nothing, taking the datapad from Varian, quickly reading the screen:

1105–1115 HRS. GARDEN PROMENADE LOOP 3: DEPLOY 1 SWEETLING

The datapad crumbled in his hand, the acid pouring from his fingertips, his eyes clouded over momentarily. The respirator hissed laboriously, trying to keep up with the strain. “**Voxx**,” he spat, the name tasting like bile in his mouth. The sound that ripped from his throat made Varian flinch, his teal gloves flying to his glasses.

“Deploy?!” he hissed. “A ‘Sweetling’?! He treats me like a common *errand boy*!” His fist slammed into the adjacent wall, shattering the reinforced metal, sending a shower of sparks into the dark. He stormed over to the console, his fingers hammering into the keys. “He wants

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the Garden Promenade. A park. Easily contained and sterilised.” A map of Titan flashed on the screen, landing on a central, glittering tower. “The Helix Spire in Aetherion,” he smiled.

Varian gasped with glee behind him. “Master! That is wonderful! The command pinnacle, the chapel, the Obris Vault!”

“Yours for the scavenging,” he said coldly.

“A Quasar-level battle there will surely be catastrophic. Their communications will be on the fritz!” The cherry-rat was almost jumping with joy.

The massive vat doors began to grind open, the grates beneath draining the containment tanks. The doors unfolded and, with the sound of tearing flesh, two of the monsters leapt out with terrifying speed. Their claws gashed the chamber floor as they let out a synchronised, ground-shaking roar that was part mechanic and part roar.

Varian was thrown back, his whole body trembling as he scrambled to his feet, laughing maniacally. “Oh, they are alive and kicking!” he giggled in pure ecstasy.

“Oh, they are *much* more than that, Varian,” Fane rumbled, his chest filling with paternal pride. He stepped forward, his exo-suit a mere toy next to the masterpieces he had wrought. He placed a gauntleted hand on the head of the nearest creature. “You see, your ‘Sweetlings’ are failures. Mindless, screaming, pathetic beasts. These...” He turned the creature's head to Varian. “...can think. They can reason. They can fight. And they can hate.”

Varian whipped his glasses off. “Think? But... but... the mutation process... the neural decay—”

“Is a problem only for lesser minds,” Fane snapped. “These were my most loyal servants, Varian. Dregs who worshipped me, who gave me everything. And in return,” he turned, showing a matching patch of skin and sinew, “I harvested them. I stripped them of their weakness, their

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fear, their pathetic, breakable bodies. I stitched their acid-resistant hides into my armour and gave them the strength of thousands of men. In perfect, indestructible, eternal vessels.”

The monster under his hand turned, its massive steel helmet retracted, revealing a singular glowing green optic in a mass of regenerative flesh and brain tissue. “Master,” it rasped.

“I want to rip Titan apart,” Fane continued. “It’s not just their flesh I want... it’s their souls. And I’ll start with the eyes.”

He slammed a fist on the activation panel, and the massive transport bay doors began to open to reveal a colossal funeral transport. He typed in the coordinates quickly, feeling his blood slowly simmer down, the joy of the moment finally settling over him like a cloak. “This is revenge, Varian. They thought they could cripple me, keep me from my rightful place. I am **owed** this! It is my **birthright**! It is my **destiny**! **And NO ONE WILL GET. IN. MY. WAY!**”

The monsters in front of him quivered in fear, and Varian’s face was a sickly-pale colour. He raised an arm to the transport and the two monsters were in it in a flash, their massive bodies barely contained, the thrusters groaning.

“Find me the strongest person. And kill them. **KILL THEM ALL!**” He punched in the release protocols, the transport pod sealing shut. The next second, they were on their way, moving toward Aetherion like a rocket.

Fane turned, the gears in his chestplate whining softly. “And now,” he said, his voice composed again, “I need to take care of my little uprising problem.”

Varian blinked out of his fevered awe, wiping the sweat from his forehead with a trembling hand. “You mean the Ash Blight Rebellion?” he asked tentatively.

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Fane snarled, his hands already moving across the console, pulling up the network full of their rebel chatter. They thought they were being clever with their fracture-code pulses, encrypted signal trails, and botched attempts at radio silence.

“They’re festering in the Verge,” he muttered finally. “He wants me to come; he wants a spectacle. He always did like the theatre.” He pointed to the console, turning the screen towards Varian. “There, a convoy. More than likely a mobile clinic or lab filled with the sick and injured,” he sneered.

“Perfect!” Varian’s voice broke through in reverence. “But... it could be a trap, Master? They have kept well hidden until now—”

Fane’s laugh cut him off, the sound crackling through the exo-suit’s modulator like static. “Pray tell, Doctor. What could they possibly trap me with? Vexal knows what I am capable of. He wouldn’t *dare* bait me.”

He brought up the payload interfaces; the convoy feeds flickered in the low-energy light, displaying row upon row of injured Dregs, no doubt the Dregs caught in Varian’s little Sweetlings.

“Bring me Specimen 88 and 97,” he ordered.

Varian darted off, issuing the release sequences to two more of Fane’s monsters. Acid sluiced into the drains as the vat doors peeled open, the beasts leaping forward towards Fane. He turned and stalked to the hangar roof, his exo-suit humming with the gathered energy. He turned, eyes raking over his creations one more time before he rocketed out into the early morning light.

In a flash the Verge sprawled beneath him, the gnarled tangles of green-and-black canopied over the dense forest in a protective shield. He slowed and spread his arms wide,

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lowering as acid spewed from his body in torrents. Acid that he had been storing for over twenty cycle-years, concentrated and vile.

The trees sizzled below him, the deluge boiling through the emerald canopy like fire. The red-and-green medical transport below them exploded in a halo of light. Screams echoed through his ears pleasantly as he swept low, enjoying the delightful chorus of pain. Behind him, he heard his monsters land like meteors, crashing through the burnt canopy and immediately laying waste to all they saw.

As Fane slowly descended, dust and blood swirled around his feet, misting with the acid and rising around his knees. He knew he didn't hit the main transport carrying the civilians, but it was here, and something that large couldn't move very fast in the tangled mess of a jungle. He would have Vexal's little rebellion squashed before lunch. And get a bit of exercise while he was at it.

Chapter 30

Mereen adjusted the delicate fall of her stark white gown, the medical-grade weave falling gently over her backless frame. She sat alone beneath the glowing dome of the Council Chamber, her eyes closed, the threads of thought whispering through the air like unseen silk. The massive taffeite table was currently empty save for her, the painite doors shielding her mind from the onslaught of thought.

Almost as if on cue, the massive red gemstone door swung open silently. Mereen opened her eyes to see the first to enter was Lord Cassien of the House of King, his polished gold breastplate casting fractured light against the floor. His posture and frown oozed with disdain, his thoughts loud and predictable: Dreg eradication, a pure upper class of Apexes and Luminals only.

Behind him, Lady Isalya Solaris drifted in like a winter mist, her light-blue skin tinged with frost, her voice high with disappointment. The House of Solaris were masters at intelligence gathering, medical research, and genetic preservation. Overseeing most of Cryothorne's facilities,

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they were essential to the balance of Titan. And Mereen knew, without having to use her psionic energies, that the Solaris family wanted Fane dealt with swiftly, wanting to avoid war at all costs.

General Titus Valkyrie strode in next, cloaked in burnished red, his fiery hair flaming with every word. His family kept Forgedeep's military and industrial complex burning at full tilt, and had been for most of Titan's history. After his daughter bonded with an Ashdog, he had taken in the mutt, seeing the usefulness in a mixed breed, she supposed. He was a weapon, though, and Mereen needed an army as it was. Valkyrie's anger was explosive; the rebellion had hit him the hardest, stealing military-grade weapons and tech, leaving the Luminals and Echelons scrambling to protect themselves.

He was in a heated conversation with the Ambassador for the House of Kairen. They had full control of the Nocturne district and a large hand in supplying enforcers for the T.E.B. Never appearing in person, they always sent an Ambassador through whom they spoke using neural links. The Ambassador was draped in opaque fabrics to shield his sensitive, pale skin from the UV rays, their nocturnal state clashing with the daylight hours.

Behind them trickled in minor envoys, some from the House of Vaelith to represent Blackroot Verge. The Verge having no formal house, but instead a commune of matriarchal-led houses. Their green skin stood in sharp contrast to their ivory robes, their voices melodious but grave.

The table was full, and the unease was thick enough for her to taste. "The quorum is full," she said softly. "Let us begin."

Cassien King was on his feet before she even finished speaking. "We should glass the Verge. Fane will burn out along with this pathetic rebellion." He pounded the table with a thick finger. "We send the T.E.B. to clear out Sector Seven and then torch the place."

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Mereen wasn't fazed; she had already begun latching onto the edges of his mind, his outburst a perfect distraction for her psionic energy. "Councillor King," she said smoothly, "torching a whole district to kill one man is a strategy best left to madmen."

Cassien sat down heavily, his lips twitching, but clearly lacking a formal argument against cold logic.

"We need precision." Solaris stood delicately. "Fane is a cold wound, and we need to permanently end him, but not at the expense of millions."

Titus Valkyrie snorted, standing in a fiery rush. "Precision? While my facilities are being stripped bare? Five caravans were gutted just this week! My own engineers are defecting to the uprising, and yet you think our biggest problem is the one-man show?"

The Nocturne Ambassador rose abruptly, turning his heavily veiled head toward Mereen and waiting patiently for Valkyrie to reseal himself. "Nocturne has no desire for a civil war, but if your Apex Corps cannot secure Fane soon, the full T.E.B. will be sent in. The populace does not take well to a military-controlled state, and we would be at an even greater risk of losing our control to the Rebellion. We would not only lose our places, but we would be outcast to the wilds without fail. If the people are merciful. And we *know* they will not be."

A ripple of cold murmurs echoed through the room as he sat back down, his body clearly exhausted from the strain of the neural link over such a long distance.

Mereen's fingers traced a slow circle against the cold purple stone of the table; the mental threads in the room leaped out at her. Rage, fear, uncertainty. She stood quietly, walking around the table slowly. "We are being pulled into a war, not by the Rebellion's ideals, nor by Fane's

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insanity,” she said, her bare feet whispering against the crystal floor. “We are being pulled in by fear. We cannot afford fear.”

“Then **what**,” Cassien muttered bitterly, “do you propose we do?”

Mereen stopped beside him, feeling her energy float around him like a halo. “We pull the rebellion apart at the seams. We infiltrate them quietly, and divide them into fractions. The Apex Corps will handle Fane in public acts of heroism. If the public wants to feel safe and protected, a crumbling rebellion will be the last place they would run. And,” she moved behind Lady Solaris, “I already have someone installed. They will be initiating contact today. Once they are trusted by them, it will only be a matter of time before the Ash Blight Rebellion falls apart.”

Having Bryn Aleric already in place was a balm the Council needed, and she let her psionic threads retract from their minds.

“Your confidence is noted, Chancellor,” Solaris said, standing, her frosty blue skin almost glittering under the light. “But this ignores the immediate, physical threat. The attack on the Catalyst Wells shows just how far Fane will go to destroy Titan.”

“The tremors from the Well Three attack caused massive magma displacement,” An envoy from the Verge said, standing briefly. “We lost two mining platforms and a full foundry. And they aren’t stopping!”

The table erupted into heated conversation, and Mereen didn’t try to calm them. She drifted slowly to the head of the table, letting her psionic subjugation work slowly, brushing along the minds of the attendees. She tasted guilt on one envoy’s mind and looked deeper, finding thoughts of leaked routes, secret dossiers on sympathisers, and even thoughts of defecting.

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It took a small effort not to react, and she made a mental note to plug the leak before too much damage was done.

“If Forgedeeep falls, then we lose access to our main atmospheric stabiliser!” Valkyrie’s explosive flames flared over the table. “If the Dregs have their way, we will all be breathing poison within half a cycle-year!”

“Dryst is testing us!” Cassien shouted, his Solar Resonance energy shining brightly. “I move we take Dryst out immediately, especially if we are infiltrating the rebellion. Giving Fane any time will only result in havoc!”

An aide glided in through the doors softly, her face pale as a ghost. She almost ran to Mereen’s side, placing a datapad before her. Her mind flared reading the alert:

SOS: MIRIDAN HOLLOW ATTACKED: MEDICAL CONVOY TRAVELLING THROUGH THE VERGE TARGETED. REPORTS OF ACID RAIN. BIOCHEMICAL SIGNATURES MATCH FANE S. DRYST. SEND ALL REINFORCEMENTS AND THE T.E.B. ENFORCERS!

Mereen carefully placed the pad down, her hand shaking slightly. The room had gone stone-quiet, waiting for her next words. “Lord Cassien, General Valkyrie. Motion granted. Fane has attacked Miridan Hollow, Blackroot Verge's medical convoy. They are requesting not only immediate backup, but T.E.B. enforcers. I’ll be deploying Operatives King and Solaris to personally handle this threat.”

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Cassien rose, his golden armour gleaming. “Perfect! I am satisfied,” he said staunchly. Valkyrie was already excusing himself, tapping into his comtech and barking orders, fire blooming from his irises.

Lady Solaris brushed her fingers through the top of her comtech, eyes scanning the details of the alert. “Very well. I will coordinate Cryothorne's aerial transports. We'll bring medical and recovery drones.”

Mereen inclined her head. “Coordinate with the Vaelith family as well.”

Solaris nodded and turned, leaving a frosty cloud in her wake. The Nocturne Ambassador dipped his head slightly and followed Solaris out, the envoys hot on his heels. Cassien swept out with Valkyrie, already coordinating their weapons effort.

The painite doors closed behind them with a heavy thud, and Mereen closed her eyes for a beat. Fane's unexpected attack being almost so close in time to Voxx's scheduled one seemed like a directly malicious attack on their agreement. The rebellion was another unpleasant surprise, and she wondered if he was attacking Titan or lashing out against the rebellion specifically. With that monster, both were equally as probable.

She opened her eyes and checked the time, before she strode out of the Council Chamber to her office, waving away the hovering aides. She sat stiffly and pressed a chime, the doors swinging open once more to reveal Captain Darius Valkyrie. She could feel the warm thrum of his anxiety and welcomed him in with a wave of her hand. His black Apex uniform was immaculate, but his hair was tousled; she wondered if it was from him or someone else.

“Chancellor,” he greeted with a stiff salute.

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“Captain,” she said smoothly, motioning for him to sit. He sat slowly, his posture rigid. He gave a glowing report on Nyx’s recovery, reintegration, and stability. She only half-listened, not even hiding her psionic probes, ensuring he was telling the truth.

“Chancellor, I would like to make an official request to permanently Bond with Operative Nyx. And for the cessation of all contraceptive protocols.”

Her eyebrows shot up, and she forced a thin smile. “A permanent Bond,” she mused, rising stiffly from her chair. She circled the desk, pacing around him slowly, her mind probing his hard, ignoring his clear discomfort. “An ambitious request, Captain. You seek to bond with a Quasar-class anomaly and sweep her away into a picture-perfect family life?”

“She is already a strong asset, Chancellor, I believe that—”

“You believe,” she interrupted, her voice soft. She stopped pacing in front of him. “Your belief is noted. But it seems like your reports are compromised by your... *affection*. Dr. Vaelith’s medical logs are similarly... biased.”

“*I require a direct audit*,” she whispered in his mind.

Darius physically recoiled like she had slapped him. “High Chancellor, I honestly don’t feel comfortable doing that considering—”

“The Valkyrie debt?” she bit out. She felt his body shiver, his mind panicking through the memories. The official story was a simple House trade infraction. The truth, which only she, he, and his grandfather knew, was financial treason. When Lord Titus Valkyrie had been in his prime, he had been caught embezzling trillions in raw materials from Forgedeep, diverting them to off-world black-market sites, effectively crippling their entire military production for decades. A crime he should have been executed for, but instead he sold off his mutt of a grandson to be an

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AAN strongman. She certainly didn't see the mutt running off for a perfect life ever being a part of the deal. Him leaving with Nyx would leave a massive power gap in their force as well.

"If you refuse, then I will have no choice but to believe you are lying to me. Your House, your name, your history will all be formally investigated at the next public tribunal."

He looked trapped, his jaw tight, and she could feel his fury, but at the end of the day he was a good soldier and always a responsible son. His shoulders slumped in defeat. "Very well, Chancellor," he said, his voice tight with emotion.

"Very well... **what?**" she pushed.

"I agree to a direct audit." His voice was tight with emotion.

Mereen nodded and turned her back to him, undoing the clasp of her gown with a snap. The starched fabric fell to the floor in a whisper of clothes, leaving her bare. She heard him shift behind her, standing and dropping his uniform trousers as she pulled up her terminal. Opening his medical reports from Rhea Vaelith, she began scanning through the contents, reaching out with her psionic subjugation, tearing through his mind.

Darius groaned; the intensity of her invasion would have crumbled a regular person, but being mixed-race he was able to endure it, barely. He entered her slowly, his massive size stretching her, his Magma energy searing through her body. She immediately dampened his energy, feeling his body cry out in pain from his internal temperature dropping so suddenly. He struggled to keep his pace as she sifted through his thoughts, his emotions, his most private feelings. He couldn't lie, he couldn't run, his energy allowing her a direct channel to the deepest parts of him. She felt his love for Nyx, his vulnerability, his hope.

"Such fervour," she sneered aloud, "you truly care about this... anomaly." She glanced behind her; the Ashdog was already slicked with sweat, his body shaking from the cold. He

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already knew Nyx's name was Myth, but he didn't know about her connection to the Dregs. Pitiful.

She was disappointed that he was blind to the danger lurking under his own nose, blinded by emotion and feelings, the same way his mother was. He flinched behind her as she forced him to relive the moment his grandfather got caught, the crushing weight of the truth, how easily he was traded. He picked up pace, his resentment surging through him, and she relished the renewed roughness of his pace.

A high-priority alert flashed on Mereen's main console and she waved it away for it to immediately repopulate. She opened it with a deep sigh: a second attack, but in Aetherion. It wasn't too bad, even though it was their command centre; she knew Voxx and Nyx were already en route. She dismissed the alert and pulled up Nyx's or Myth's med report.

"Chancellor," Darius grunted behind her, "I have to go if Aetherion is under attack—"

"Commander Voxx and Operative Nyx are already en route," she said, a slow smile spreading across her face. She could feel him trembling physically, and she admired how strong his restraint was. Her mutation was formidable, but he could easily end her if he lost control. The thought sent a thrill through her core, but she kept her expression neutral, her eyes focusing on the terminal.

"You are a fascinating study, Captain," her voice was flat. "So full of passion and duty, but so blind to the truths that lie right before you." She surged against him, her energy flooding through his temporal lobe, his body shuddering under the weight. She moved her hips with brutal, mechanical precision, driving him deeper and harder. She could feel his resistance crumbling as the pleasure started building in spite of himself.

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She could feel his body tensing, the full-body scans of Nyx on her terminal triggering a reaction in his exhausted brain. His muscles clenched as he desperately tried to hold back, but she poured her energy into him like a tidal wave, his pain feeding her pleasure, pushing her closer to the edge. His breath was ragged as he struggled with the tidal wave of sensations pouring out of her body, his hips lifting to meet her thrusts against his will.

She felt his desperate need to be loyal and she turned to see his eyes had darkened from their normal fiery orange to a dull brown. She dampened his energy more, causing his body to tense, his muscles clenching as he teetered on the brink of passing out. She released his energy just enough and, with a brutal thrust of her hips, sent him hurtling over the edge. His body convulsed on top of her as he struggled to get breath, his knees almost buckled under him. She didn't stop until her own release crashed over her a heartbeat later.

As the final waves of pleasure faded, she stood up and returned to her seat, leaving him to pull his trousers on shakily. She felt as refreshed as he looked worn, and she frowned. "Captain. Your ear is bleeding."

His hand went instinctively to his ear and he nodded silently.

"See the medical team here immediately. That's an order. And your request for permanent Resonance Bonding is under advisement. As to the matter of your family's continuing loyalty, I will confer with General Valkyrie to ensure there are no conflicts."

He gave her a jerky nod and saluted stiffly, before walking out on unsteady legs.

Mereen watched him go with a cold flicker of satisfaction. She turned to the console, pulling up the feeds from both monster incidents, focusing on Aetherion. The city was being bled dry and her assets were in chaos.

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She sighed heavily, fingers tapping absent-mindedly, before coolly redirecting the T.E.B. They were already spread thin, but it couldn't be helped. She would have a discussion with Voxx once he returned; something was clearly very wrong.

Chapter 31

Aetherion glittered beneath Nyx's boots, the crystal walkways criss-crossing high above glowing gardens overflowing with brightly coloured flowers. At every corner, art installations shimmered between high-end storefronts. An opulent testament to the pinnacle of Aetherion beauty. People leisurely strolled to their destinations in flowing, brightly coloured clothes that fluttered delicately in the wind.

After they had seen Rhea again, Darius had wanted to show her his command deck in Aetherion. Where they would spend a lot of time whenever she was off light duty. It had been an imposing place, a hive of information and enforcers. They had picked up Synn Astra and Taryn Faye, both thrilled to have the opportunity to patrol with Nyx and Darius.

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She walked between them, her boots clicking against the crystal loudly. She tried to maintain her calm exterior, but her mind was whirling. Darius had to leave midway through the patrol to meet High Chancellor Mereen. He said he hadn't been scheduled until next week, but he supposed since he was on light duty and she probably had an open window, she had moved up the appointment. That had been almost two hours ago.

She checked her comtech for the fifth time that minute, her pulse skipping every time the screen came up empty.

"Almost to the last metre of our patrol," Synn said, floating gently along beside her.

"Then we can head back to headquarters."

"Should we wait for Darius?" Taryn asked, her wild blue hair bouncing erratically.

Nyx forced a smile. "Let's go back to headquarters after. Meetings are bound to run long considering everything that has happened with Fane and the Verge Convoy."

Synn nodded in agreement. "They may want reinforcements as well. I don't have the details, but it seems like Fane is putting up a good fight."

Her heart sank; she could feel it in her bones, a gnawing sense of unease. She tried her comtech one more time before trying his private channel. A cold, automated reply floated across the screen:

CHANNEL RESTRICTED BY HIGH CHANCELLOR'S DIRECT AUTHORITY

Nyx felt the blood rush from her face and she slowly lowered her arm. She forced herself not to think as they continued their patrol. When they reached the summit of the Helix Spire, they began to finish their report. The beauty of the plaza gave her a sense of comfort as she

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looked down, the five kilometres to the surface of Titan obscured by a thick layer of clouds. The airborne city was a work of wonder, one of Titan's crown jewels rivalling even Helion.

She turned suddenly, a high-pitched tearing sound screaming through the air. She looked to Taryn momentarily, but the sound wasn't coming from her. She squinted into the sky before seeing a massive, matte-black transport hurtling through the air so fast the front end was on fire. It crashed through the air-defence drones and into the plaza, the crystal floors shattering, sending civilians screaming and plummeting into the depths of the building. The coffin-shaped transport groaned, the end tearing open as a massive, multi-jointed steel claw ripped through the metal.

An alarm blared overhead, the plaza's speakers immediately issuing warnings:

**THREAT LEVEL QUASAR: ALL CIVILIANS EVACUATE! HOSTILE
UNREGISTERED BIOMECHANICALS DETECTED! CITY-WIDE CIVILIAN
EVACUATION PROTOCOL INITIATED!**

Nyx's heart raced as her shaky hands fumbled with her comtech, trying to establish an emergency pathway to Darius, but it was still restricted. She whirled around, trying to put together her thoughts. She needed to get the civilians out, but the only way was to warp them. She had never warped this many people without touching them, and the nearest safe platform was a little more than a hundred metres away.

She gritted her teeth and started anyway, the energy ebbing out of her body with each group. She didn't focus on the monster; she hoped Synn and Taryn could at least delay it while she pushed harder. There were hundreds of people in the chaos around her, the civilians' screams blurring away as they found themselves shooting through space and time to safety.

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She heard a screech behind her that sounded like Taryn, and she pushed herself harder, faster. Her eyes were clouding slightly from the blood leaking from her tear ducts, and she felt the cold grip of panic set in. She couldn't save all the survivors and have enough energy left over to fight whatever had just fallen from the sky. But she didn't have a choice.

As she found the last civilian she could see alive and warped them to safety, she felt a small prick of relief as she opened her comtech. It was an incoming call from Commander Voxx.

"I'm en route," his voice crackled through the speaker. She spun to yell to Taryn and Synn, but another monster was already there. She gasped, *there were two of them*.

Twenty-five feet of hulking metal and seething with anger, the monster's fist caught her chin sharply. She rocketed into the air, barely leaving time to create a barrier before she received another blow. Its strikes came hard and fast, not giving her an opening to defend herself as her body crashed through an emergency drone. She used the temporary cover to get her bearings and fire a shot of re-forged metal at the monster. It deflected off, not even leaving a scratch as she came crashing back to the Spire's destroyed upper floor. She pulled herself up to see Synn unconscious, a bloody mess in Taryn's lap. Blood was dripping from Taryn's mouth from using her Sonic Rend too many times, but her mouth still hung open slightly as she tried to force sound out. Nyx pushed with power, creating a small rift in time, slowing the monster and using her other hand to warp both of them away to the other survivors.

She felt a staggering blow to her back, almost making her black out. She tried to dissolve it, tear its energy from it, but the acid-ridden metal didn't budge. She felt the burn of the acid flood through her system, and she flinched back. She felt the monster pull back, and she tried to run. She saw it pull back to pull out a massive cannon. She could feel the energy dampening coming from it and dodged the first shot just in time. The shot exploded behind her, causing the

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spire to shake as the crystal broke, sending them plummeting to the floor below in a shower of crystal and twisted metal. The other monster rose from the floor and pulled a massive sword from its chest, flaring to life in a fizz of energy and acid.

Before she could breathe, they were on her again and she shot a powerful beam of pure energy at the monster, blasting through its arm. It earned her a direct punch to the gut, sending her flying into the open air, blood flooding her mouth and spewing into the atmosphere. The monster leapt after her without hesitation, its arm springing back into place to prepare for the next shot. Rocket-type fissures in their backs propelled them through the air towards her and she felt the world go hazy as she tried to dodge, zig-zagging her way through the frigid sky. The monster with the cannon fired again, the nullifying shot grazing her, draining her power. She stuttered in the air before falling like a stone.

The second monster was on her in an instant, its sword oozing acid as it raised it for a killing blow.

She was going to die here.

With a scream, she created a disc of solid space, kicking off it and sending herself shuttling sideways, smashing into the crystal ceiling of the adjacent spire. She felt spiderwebs of pain crack up her legs as she landed hard, skidding across a polished obsidian floor and crashing into the glittering art installations. The two monsters landed seconds later, their immense weight cracking the spire's floor.

“Kill. The. Strongest,” the monster in front of her grated, dragging its acid-sword behind it, the acid eating through the obsidian in sickening rivets.

The other monster was already charging the cannon, and she was in a point-blank killing shot. Nyx tried to raise a shield, but her powers were still sputtering.

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She was going to die here.

The thought screamed through her skull as she tried to warp away, blood pouring from her mouth in the effort. She looked down to see her leg almost completely shattered, and her ribcage sitting unnaturally. She didn't feel any pain, but her body refused to heal, refused to move.

She bowed her head as a sonic boom shattered through the air. A blur of silver light slammed into the monsters, the force driving the monsters through the wall and back into the air. Voxx knelt beside her, his command suit almost immediately soaked in her blood. "You are a mess, little mouse," he hissed, his voice thrumming with anger. He turned and rocketed through the new hole, his wings flaring to form a defensive shield, engaging the monster with the massive sword in a brutal clash for dominance. His wings acted as shields and blades as he slashed through the monster's claws, causing it to spew acid in the air. It hit a high-speed transit line, the civilian carriage plummeting into the clouds, dropping down to Titan below.

Nyx pushed herself up, pulling matter from everything around them, the building shaking as she dropped obsidian spikes hard at the monster, sending the cannon flying. The monster converged on her, landing a sickening blow to her jaw. Her head snapped back and she tried again to absorb the energy and turn it into dust, the metal groaning around its frame. It spewed acid at her in a shower and she tried to cover herself with a shield, the acid burning her skin. She screamed, the pain shocking her body, and her energy fluctuating wildly.

"Get back!" Voxx screamed from above her, his voice amplified by his power. She tried to scramble out of the way as his six wings melted together in a cascade of light, reforming into a singular pair of colossal wings.

The Dreg chasing her looked up, shrieking at him defiantly.

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“Annihilation: Collapse Sequence!” His voice radiated coolly as he unleashed a devastating rain of solar projectiles. Thousands of them poured from his wings and slammed into the crystal roof and engulfed both the monsters. They screamed in pain as the energy superheated their metal armour, finally melting through their impenetrable exterior.

She saw her chance and focused what was left of her energy on the monsters, hurling a spear of energy through them in a vicious implosion of dark energy. The monsters staggered, one’s limbs locking in place completely, its body sagging under the melting metal.

Voxx ignited his wings in a burst of celestial light and heat, his body radiant from the energy. “Holy Divine Treasure of Pride: **Ego!**” His voice sliced through the chaos, golden sigils bursting into existence in the air around them. Voxx dove forward, his energy magnifying through the sigils, turning the world white.

Nyx hit the floor hard from the shockwave, the top of the spire bursting open and shattering into the atmosphere. Heat washed over her, and she heard the monsters screech in pain as they were vapourised.

The building tilted precariously, crashing into the Helix Spire next to it, hurling Nyx's body through the glass and out the broken walls.

“**Myth!**” Voxx screamed as he dove for her, his wings flickering violently, the right one hanging on by a thread.

She felt her eyes fog over as they plummeted into the cloud layer, the world around becoming a swirling, disorienting mess of white and red. The freezing air whipped past her and the lack of oxygen numbed her senses. Her world darkened, and she hoped that Voxx could catch her before she fell to Titan’s surface below.

Chapter 32

The air around him was freezing and the wind screamed past in a deafening roar. Voxx could see Myth's limp and bloody body disappear into the cloud layer. He knew the mechanical mess that sprawled below the glittering clouds would tear her apart.

I can't lose her.

His wings were still fused together, refusing to re-form, tearing him apart as the bone cracked and his flesh burned from the flood of energy.

He burst through the cloud cover to see Myth bounce off a high-speed rail tube like a rag doll, spinning wildly in the air from the impact. He tucked his wings tight and dove harder, the

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wind cutting his face like a knife, his eyes screaming from the pressure. He caught her just beneath the last grav-ring, his arms and head tucking around her, his wings pulling tight, cocooning them in. He poured his Solar energy into a hard shell around them as he felt the first impact. A thermal conduit sliced his left side open, blood spraying through his wings. He felt a support beam shatter through his right wing in a scream of metal and exploding ice. He pushed his head down harder as they hit the guts of the structural spine. He was thrown temporarily sideways as he bounced off a fire-suppression pipe, the pressurised burst freezing against his back. He gritted his teeth as they slammed into the ground layer of Aetherion, the maintenance tunnel exploding upward in a shockwave as his legs crashed into the ground.

Everything went white with pain, his leg snapping sideways abruptly before everything blinked black.

He surged back to consciousness with a ragged gasp, his lungs searing with each breath as he tasted the foul, metallic air. His eyes blurred over, almost blacking out from the suffocating pain. His head drummed agonisingly and he felt the cold crushing through his bones. He struggled to push himself onto his elbows, trying to separate his body from the freezing ground. His wings were gone, just ruined sinew hanging from his back like dead roots. All six were completely torn from their sockets, his nerves twitching, sending shockwaves of pain thrumming through his back. His left leg was shattered in three places and a shard of steel had impaled him through the right shoulder. He was pinned to a twisted pipe, the icy-cold metal burning his flesh. He tried to look around, but his right eye was completely swollen shut, a pulsating mass of bruised flesh. His mind whirled dizzily; Myth wasn't making a sound and he couldn't see her. A jolt of terror cut through the fog of pain and snapped him into action.

GET UP!

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His mind screamed at him, a desperate plea to his battered body. He pressed his hand to the gushing wound on his shoulder, focusing his energy. Slowly, searing heat erupted under his palm. A scream tore from his throat as the energy cauterised the flesh. He snapped his teeth shut, the white-hot agony and smell of burning flesh threatening to consume him. But it worked, and the bleeding slowed to a crawl from the exit wound, the blood congealing in the cold.

He looked down, his voice a hoarse whisper. "Sorry." He pressed both his hands to her shattered leg, the raw Solar energy lancing out of his fingers. With her leg severed, the wound sealed off immediately, burning the skin shut in a crude patch. The smell of burnt flesh rushed through the air and Myth cried faintly, passing in and out of consciousness.

His body spasmed from the effort; blood gushed from his nose and he almost blacked out again. He collapsed forward over her, his hand shaking violently. He rolled her onto his back, the sinew and fried energy veins scorching in pain as he forced his energy inward, raising his body temperature and creating a small dome of protective heat around them. It scorched through his system, his body shaking violently from the exertion, his eye blurring over. He briefly tapped his arm, confirming his comtech was dead, and gritted his teeth. He had to think. They had to get out before they froze to death.

He began to drag them mindlessly, feeling his blood freeze behind him. His energy began to crack over his skin, the Solar flares erupting in bursts as his control started to fail. His body convulsed on the frozen ground, Myth almost sliding away as he grabbed at her, his vision flickering from the pain, his shoulder and back screaming for relief.

A sterile room, a glint of a needle.

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He forced his body up again, biting down on his tongue and forcing Myth onto his back.

“She won’t feel a thing.”

He snarled, spitting blood from his mouth and dragging himself forward. He followed his nose, trying to find a scent, or a wisp of warmer air in the dark. His head was ringing constantly and his balance kept slipping sideways, the dark suffocating him. The air was thick with rust and dust, wires hanging like webbing, slowing his progress. He felt a warm wisp of air to his left and he immediately slung his body towards it. It felt like a maintenance corridor, barely big enough for him, let alone Myth.

He fought his rising panic and gingerly slid her down to his crushed legs, the pain ripping another scream from his throat. His eyes darkened and his energy flickered violently. He dropped his shoulder and dragged his body through, her limp body precariously balanced on his broken leg.

It was a desperate crawl in the dark, the temperature slowly rising, spurring him on. He finally reached the hatch at the end, but it didn’t budge. His fingers clawed at the rusted edges, the ice cutting into his fingers.

He took a deep breath, trying to steady his breathing, a cold thread of dread setting in. He slammed his shoulder against the hatch. It shuddered, cracking open, a sweet scent wafting out. He threw his whole weight against the opening, his energy surging in desperation. It gave way with a metallic screech and the warm air hit him like a dream. Bioluminescent moss lit the grove in shades of blue and green, and a soft breeze wafted through the leaves overhead. The sun was setting, casting everything in an eerie orange glow, bright in his eyes after being in complete

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darkness. As he dragged himself out of the maintenance pipe onto the soft forest floor, he barely caught Myth's dead weight, his arms screaming in pain.

He blinked hard, trying to focus, his world spinning in a dizzying arc of pain and exhaustion. It seemed what had made the clearing was a monstrous-sized sequoia, its trunk hollowed out by time and lined with thick moss.

The air hit his lungs, sweet and strong. Sunlight. She was laughing ahead of him, her bare feet quick against the soft grass. Her dark hair a tangled mess of braids and wildflowers, flowing behind her.

He squeezed his eyes shut, trying to block out the memories, throwing his body forward, dragging them to the tree. His mind was swirling painfully as he tried to think of a plan if something was nested inside. As he approached the entrance, a flock of Crested Phasurs took to the sky, their massive wings brushing against his body in a rush of colour and sound. They were bright, crystal-like creatures, their plumage shimmering in the fading light, their eyes wide with fear as they fled the intrusion.

He dragged Myth behind him into the hollow, her body like a broken doll in his arms. He pushed farther in, briefly checking the interior before laying her gently in the feather-lined nest.

Her condition was terrible; he brushed her matted hair from her face, and she stirred just enough to let him know she was still alive. His mind warbled, darkness threatening to set in.

He dragged himself forward, the icy ground scraping against his broken leg.

It was pouring rain; they were soaked. She was laughing against his chest. "Put those wings away and enjoy the rain, Thal!"

Smiling at her, he bent down and kissed her gently, her lips sweet and warm.

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Pain shot through his body, sending him rushing back to the present. With shaking hands, he gathered nearby rocks and sticks. His fingers were cut and bleeding, making every touch excruciating. Soon a small fire crackled to life, the last spark of his energy setting it ablaze. A glow danced along the wooden walls, the heat immediately filling up the cosy space. He sank against the wall, his body savouring the warmth, his eyes blurring over.

His eyes slipped shut.

She was screaming his name. He was thrashing against enforcers, trying to break free. Her eyes were wide and wild. "Please don't let them take me!" she cried.

"I promise I'll come get you!" he screamed, his voice cracking as her small frame was dragged from the room.

"Such emotional children," a chilling voice said behind him.

He jerked, his grip on consciousness slipping; he turned to look at the nest. Her breathing had steadied out, but her body was a disjointed mangle, her right leg's stump muddy and covered in burnt blood.

His head drooped heavily, the firelight dancing and twisting around him, his eyes slipping closed. He felt his body surrender to exhaustion, his last thoughts a swirl of worry and pain.